

CORONAVIRUS UPDATE FROM KIAMBIU



ROSSHOLME KENYA

Registered as a Charitable Incorporated Organisation (CIO), Charity No 1178553

Little did we imagine when we wrote our last newsletter and had our last Trustees Meeting, that life would have taken such a dramatic turn worldwide. Several of our supporters and donors have enquired about the children and the situation generally, knowing that the spread of COVID-19 within the Kiambiu slum in particular would be likely to have a disastrous effect on our Rossholme School children.

The Kenyan Government closed all schools in mid-March and, as our Headteacher, Joyce, does not live within the slum, it has been difficult to ascertain what is happening there and to find out how our children are faring in the circumstances. School is so important for them and for many, it provides their only nutritious meal in a day.

The positive news at the moment is that there are no reported cases within Kiambiu. Following my enquiries about the situation there, I received an update through a BBC contact at the beginning of the week:

"...so far I have found out that there have been no major incidents over the last week. There is Police presence to ensure that the measures imposed by the Ministry of Health eg. social distancing, curfews, the closing down of social places, are effected. I am told through direct contact with people living within the slum, that they have not heard of any cases of COVID-19 there yet. It might be that they are 'crazy lucky' or because they have not been tested. The area is apparently calm, they have adequate water and sanitation is still considerably good.

As for the schools, all of them are closed and, until the Government has a better hold on issues, they don't know how long things will stay that way"

Current information would indicate that the virus does not thrive in hot conditions so we very much hope that this applies. I have also heard from Joyce through WhatsApp messages, voice and video messages. Her little boy Doug, was 1 year old on 9th

April but they did not celebrate in the circumstances. Birthday celebrations do not have the same significance within this community; in fact, when I first met Joyce, she knew the year of her birth and the approximate month (October or November), but she had never celebrated a birthday and she did not know the date! Her first passport had been issued for her to travel to England for the BBC 100 Women conference where we met in 2013. This



1 year old Doug

gave a date of 24th October (presumably based on her day of travel) so we celebrated with a cake and candles two days later when she came down to Rossholme in Somerset to visit! Joyce is obviously concerned about the children but is helpless and unable to do anything about things at the moment. There is however, a positive from her point of view: Doug now knows who she is! As Head of Rossholme, she has to leave Doug with a childminder for about 14 hours a day so this has given her the opportunity to spend all her time with him. Despite the circumstances, he seems a wonderfully happy little boy who is now walking and is desperately keen to communicate!

FUNDRAISING

We are a registered charity (number 1178553) which means that Gift Aid can be claimed on donations made by UK tax payers. Donations can now be made through CAFDonate which can be accessed through our website: www.rossholme.co.uk

CAFDonate will also process the GiftAid or, alternatively, if donations are made directly to the charity, a GiftAid form can be downloaded from the website and returned to: judy@rossholme.co.uk

We aim to publish a Newsletter about every 6 months so, if you know of anyone else who may be interested in receiving one by email, please let us know. In line with GDPR, we need permission for names to be on a mailing list but we assure you that it is not published anywhere; it is retained only by us and all emails are BCC'd so no list of emails is available.



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For further info please
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CHRISTMAS PARTY

Christmas seems a long time ago, particularly with everything else that has happened but, yet again, Trustee Doug sent out funds for a Christmas Party for the school children and their friends – 192 children in all. They all received books as Christmas presents and had an amazing time



NEW SCHOOL PREMISES

During the school Christmas holidays, in fact very shortly before Christmas, Joyce was informed that the current Rossholme premises were too small for the number of children and she needed to find new premises before the start of the new term on 6th January....

What a challenge! But I am sure you will, by now, have realised that our ever-resourceful Joyce will never be fazed by something like this and this is the message I received from her:

I really had a crazy December holiday. I was seriously busy and stressed up!

On December 20th, I received a call from the Ministry of Education. They talked about our school infrastructure and they advised me to look for a better place before 2020. It was really tough as I talked to them to give us time but they insisted that we've to acquire a bigger space for our kids.

We were able to get a new space with at least a space where kids can play. It's just 200 metres from where we were.

I really didn't want to bother you at all because it was a holiday and you really needed some rest.

I used the money that Eve sent us for feeding (150,000/=) for 2020 and Jacob also gave me 100,000/=. I used the money to renovate the place as it was an empty space with old structures. We also added three classes and we were able to pay rent and deposit for January.

I am pleased to say that our financial position enabled us to replenish her Rossholme coffers and to repay her husband, Jacob. We also



Preparing new premises for the school

instructed her to get the area in the middle properly surfaced to provide a play area, a much-needed improvement to our school facilities.

So Joyce, helped by her husband and others, spent her Christmas cleaning, painting, decorating and preparing new premises for the school. It was ready in time for the start of term and the children moved in but then the Ministry of Education insisted on coming in to inspect first... on 21st January, they came in and opened the new premises officially...a real triumph for Joyce.



Ministry of Education opening new premises

FUNDRAISING, DONATIONS AND SUPPORTERS

Our fundraising efforts continue apace and our Trustees are very active in their support. We are also particularly grateful to:

★ Martin Appleford, a friend we met on holiday who has taken a very active interest in Rossholme. He gave two 'sponsorship deals' (one to pay the fees annually for one child and one to fund books and stationery) as Christmas presents to friends;

★ a new regular donor, Kath Edwards... following a talk to the Pitminster Women's Institute, which also donated;

★ The Globe at Appley, Somerset (now sadly closed), where the collecting tin drew the attention of a Senior Executive of Liquidtelecom, a Kenyan based company who have now visited Rossholme in Kenya and have offered support. Unfortunately, like everything else, nothing can happen at the moment but we look forward to active support from this African based company.

★ Former Rossholme teacher, Libby Tidswell who has continued to be an active fundraiser. It was planned that I should speak to her local Hutton Moor Sports Centre (many of whose members have supported Libby's Fundraising efforts) Annual General Meeting in the hope of encouraging them to adopt Rossholme as their charity for the year but....

★ Doug Brodie's brother Hugh in USA, from whom we have now received the very generous \$10,000 donation, earmarked for the establishment of Kirsty's Place. This will be a Day Care Centre for pre-school age children which will be actioned as soon as we are able to move forwards...

★ Knights Templar, Province of Surrey for their £500 donation

★ Tushinde Children's Trust and its founder Megan Wright who continue to provide financial support and advice

★ those who kindly donate regularly and occasionally towards the funding of Rossholme